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The Nuba

Author(S): Nadel, S. F. (Siegfried Frederick)

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Conclusion

The close affinity of the two cultures is broken by one element—the obsession with witchcraft in Mesakin, which has no parallel in Korongo. With this crucial divergence certain other tribal characteristics are linked, like the crimes of violence which, in Mesakin, so often spring from the fear of witchcraft. But we discover also differences of a more subtle nature, belonging less to culture in the narrow sense than to the imponderables of temperament and disposition. Any visitor to the two tribes must notice the friendliness and cheerful temper of the Korongo, and the dour, reserved, and suspicious attitude of the Mesakin. This contrast is noticeable, not only in the intercourse with us, the strangers, but equally in the intercourse of the two groups among themselves.² Let me give an example: In Korongo the people are strikingly sociable; they constantly forgather in cheerful groups, talking and joking together. A sight like this is rare in Mesakin country. There the individuals seem self-centred, they keep to themselves and shun these friendly, informal contacts. The deep suspicion, the gloom and unhappiness which pervade the everyday life and contacts of this tribe flow, I believe, from the same source—the obsession with the threat of witchcraft.

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Our gauge of emotional stability, suicide, fits into this picture. Once more it bears out the pessimistic, neurotic mentality of the Mesakin. In Korongo informants absolutely denied the occurrence of suicide, of which indeed I found no evidence. In Mesakin the spontaneous reply was: 'There are plenty of cases.' I recorded only four—all typical instances of 'escape', reflecting a mentality which cannot withstand misfortune and frustration and (in two cases of four) the ever-present shadow of witchcraft.

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An old chief (*bareda*) stabbed himself because he had lost all his wealth. A man, long angry and unhappy, killed himself with his spear because his brothers and sisters had all died in rapid succession and people believed that he, through witchcraft, had caused their deaths. Another man killed himself from unhappiness over his brother's apparently incurable illness (though the brother later recovered). An old man, ■ 318 finally, cracked his own skull with a spade: he had refused the customary gift of a cow to his sister-son; the latter, fully supported by public opinion, seized the animal by force; mad with fury and shame and, perhaps, afraid of the familiar revenge through witchcraft, the old man ended his life.

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² If the reserve and suspicion of the Mesakin were restricted to their intercourse with us, this might be explained by the fact that the Mesakin, unlike the Korongo, had to suffer punitive police action. This experience may have contributed to their 'natural' dourness. But the fact that it did so (while in other Nuba tribes punitive patrols had no such lasting effect) would itself be evidence of the more deep rooted psychological trait.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs: hraf-support@yale.edu

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